

Word family: **nail / nails / nailed / nailing**

Base word: nail

Part of speech: mainly **noun** and **verb**

Related forms:

* **nail** (n.) — 指甲 / 趾甲；釘子

* **nail** (v.) — 用釘子固定；準確做到；抓住 / 逮住；成功完成

* **nailed** (adj./participle) — 用釘子固定的；成功完成的

* **nailing** (n./gerund) — 釘牢；準確做到

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **fingernail / toenail**

* **nail polish**

* **nail file**

* **hammer a nail**

* **nail something to something**

* **hit the nail on the head**

* **nail it**

* **nail an interview / presentation**

* **nail someone**

* **nail down**

* **bite your nails**

* **fight tooth and nail**

* **a nail in the coffin**

* **as hard as nails**

Meaning in this passage

> That reaction told me I had **hit the nail on the head**.

Here, **nail** is part of the idiom:

hit the nail on the head = 說中重點；判斷完全正確；做得正中要害

In your passage, the speaker means:

the mother's reaction showed that the gift was exactly right for her

中文翻譯：

她的反應讓我知道，我這份禮物真的**送對了 / 正中她心意**。

So here:

hit the nail on the head = 準確判斷或處理某件事，正正抓到最重要的一點

1. **nail (指甲；趾甲) — 指甲；趾甲**

A major everyday noun sense.

Practice 1

> She painted her **nails** red.

她把**指甲**塗成紅色。

Practice 2

> I broke a **nail** while opening the box.

我開盒子的時候弄斷了一隻**指甲**。

Practice 3

> His **toenail** was injured.

他的**趾甲**受傷了。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail = the hard flat part covering the end of a finger or toe

中文：

覆蓋在手指或腳趾末端的硬質部分

2. **fingernail / toenail — 手指甲 / 腳趾甲**

Practice 1

> Her **fingernails** were very short.

她的**手指甲**很短。

Practice 2

> He hurt his ****toenail**** while running.

他跑步時弄傷了****腳趾甲****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fingernail/toenail = 指手指或腳趾末端的指甲****

3. ****bite your nails — 咬指甲****

Practice 1

> She ****bites her nails**** when she's nervous.

她緊張時會****咬指甲****。

Practice 2

> Try not to ****bite your nails****.

盡量不要****咬指甲****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****bite your nails = 用牙齒咬自己的指甲，常與緊張習慣有關****

4. ****nail polish — 指甲油****

Practice 1

> She bought a new bottle of ****nail polish****.

她買了一瓶新的****指甲油****。

Practice 2

> Remove the old ****nail polish**** first.

先把舊的****指甲油****卸掉。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nail polish = 塗在指甲上的有色或透明液體化妝品****

5. **nail file — 指甲銼**

Practice 1

> She used a **nail file** to smooth the edge.

她用**指甲銼**把邊緣磨平。

Practice 2

> I keep a small **nail file** in my bag.

我袋裏放了一把小**指甲銼**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail file = 用來磨平或修整指甲邊緣的工具

6. **nail (釘子) — 釘 ; 釘子**

A completely separate major noun sense.

Practice 1

> He hammered a **nail** into the wall.

他把一口**釘子**敲進牆裏。

Practice 2

> The picture was hanging from a **nail**.

那幅畫掛在一口**釘子**上。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail = a thin pointed piece of metal used to fasten materials together

中文：

尖細的金屬固定物，用來把物件釘在一起

7. **hammer a nail — 敲釘子**

Practice 1

> He **hammered a nail** into the wood.

他把一口釘子**敲進木頭裏**。

Practice 2

> Be careful when **hammering nails**.

敲釘子時要小心。

MCQ-ready definition:

hammer a nail = 用鎚子把釘子敲入某個表面

8. **nail something to something — 用釘子把.....固定在.....**

Verb sense.

Practice 1

> He **nailed the sign to the wall**.

他用釘子把招牌**釘在牆上**。

Practice 2

> The boards were **nailed together**.

木板被**釘在一起**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail X to Y = 用釘子把 X 固定在 Y 上

9. **hit the nail on the head — 說中要害；完全說對**

This is the exact expression used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> Her reaction told me I had **hit the nail on the head**.

她的反應讓我知道自己真的**送對了 / 正中要害**。

Practice 2

> You **hit the nail on the head** when you said the real problem was communication.

你說真正問題在於溝通時，真的**一語中的**。

Practice 3

> His comment **hit the nail on the head**.

他的評論**正中問題核心**。

MCQ-ready definition:

hit the nail on the head = 說得完全正確，或準確指出事情最核心的地方

10. **nail it** — 完美做到；成功搞定

A very common informal verb use.

Practice 1

> You **nailed it**!

你**做得非常好 / 完全搞定了**！

Practice 2

> She **nailed the presentation**.

她那次簡報**表現得非常出色**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail it = informal: do something extremely well or exactly right

中文：

非正式：把某事做得非常成功、非常準確

11. **nail an interview / exam / performance — 表現極佳**

Practice 1

> He **nailed the interview**.

他面試**表現得非常好**。

Practice 2

> She completely **nailed the performance**.

她那場表演**發揮得非常出色**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail X = informal: perform X very successfully

12. **nail the answer / timing / pronunciation — 準確做到**

Practice 1

> She **nailed the pronunciation**.

她的發音**非常準確**。

Practice 2

> He **nailed the timing**.

他的時間掌握得**恰到好處**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail X = get X exactly right

中文：

把某個細節準確做到

13. **nail someone (抓住；逮到) — 抓到；逮住**

Informal.

Practice 1

> The police finally **nailed the suspect**.

警方終於**抓到了疑犯**。

Practice 2

> They **nailed him** for fraud.

他們因詐騙而**逮住 / 起訴了他**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nail someone = informal: catch, identify, or successfully prove wrongdoing by someone****

14. **nail someone for something — 因.....抓住 / 懲處某人**

Practice 1

> He was **nailed for cheating**.

他因作弊而**被抓到**。

Practice 2

> The authorities **nailed the company for tax fraud**.

當局因稅務詐騙而**查辦了那家公司**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nail someone for X = 成功發現某人做錯 X，並加以處理或懲罰****

15. **nail down something — 確定；敲定**

A major phrasal verb.

Practice 1

> We need to **nail down the date**.

我們需要**敲定日期**。

Practice 2

> Let's **nail down the details** before Friday.

我們星期五前把細節**確定下來**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail down X = make X definite, clear, or finally agreed

中文：

把事情正式確定、敲定或說清楚

16. **nail down the cause / answer — 查明；準確確定**

Practice 1

> Doctors are trying to **nail down the cause**.

醫生正嘗試**查明確實原因**。

Practice 2

> We still haven't **nailed down the exact answer**.

我們仍未**確定準確答案**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nail down X = identify something precisely after uncertainty

17. **a nail in the coffin — 令失敗更接近的一擊**

A common figurative idiom.

Practice 1

> The loss was another **nail in the coffin** for the project.

這次損失令項目更接近失敗，是**雪上加霜的一擊**。

Practice 2

> The final mistake proved to be the **last nail in the coffin**.

最後一次錯誤成為令事情徹底失敗的**最後一擊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a nail in the coffin = something that makes failure, ending, or collapse more likely or final

中文：

令某事更接近徹底失敗或結束的一個因素

18. **the final / last nail in the coffin — 最後致命一擊**

Practice 1

> Losing the main client was the **final nail in the coffin**.

失去主要客戶成為**最後致命一擊**。

Practice 2

> That decision was the **last nail in the coffin** for the plan.

那個決定令計劃**徹底沒有翻身機會**。

MCQ-ready definition:

final nail in the coffin = the final event that makes the end or failure inevitable

19. **fight tooth and nail — 拼盡全力；竭力爭取**

Practice 1

> She **fought tooth and nail** to protect the project.

她**拼盡全力**保住這個項目。

Practice 2

> They **fought tooth and nail** for every point.

他們為每一分都**全力以赴**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****fight tooth and nail = fight or struggle with maximum effort and determination****

中文：

****用盡全力去爭取或抗爭****

20. ****as hard as nails — 非常強硬；鐵石心腸 / 堅強****

Informal.

Practice 1

> The coach is ****as hard as nails****.

那個教練非常****強硬****。

Practice 2

> She may look gentle, but she's ****as hard as nails**** when necessary.

她看起來溫柔，但有需要時其實非常****強硬堅韌****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****as hard as nails = extremely tough, strong, or emotionally hard****

21. ****nail-biting — 扣人心弦的；令人緊張的****

Derived from literal nail-biting.

Practice 1

> It was a ****nail-biting finish****.

那是一個****緊張刺激的結局****。

Practice 2

> The match became ****nail-biting**** in the final minutes.

比賽最後幾分鐘變得****非常緊張刺激****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nail-biting = causing strong nervous excitement or suspense****

中文：

****緊張到令人想咬指甲的；扣人心弦的****

22. ****nail-biter — 緊張刺激的比賽 / 情況****

Practice 1

> The final was a real ****nail-biter****.

決賽真是一場****緊張到最後一刻的比賽****。

Practice 2

> The election count was a ****nail-biter****.

點票過程非常****緊張刺激****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nail-biter = informal: an event whose outcome remains uncertain until the end****

Important distinction 1: ****nail = 指甲 vs nail = 釘子****

These are two completely separate everyday noun senses.

Body

> cut your nails

剪指甲

Metal object

> hammer in a nail

敲入釘子

Context normally makes the distinction obvious.

Important distinction 2: **nail vs screw**

nail

smooth metal fastener usually hammered in.

screw

threaded fastener turned in with a screwdriver/drill.

> hammer a nail

> tighten a screw

Not interchangeable.

Important distinction 3: **crack a nail vs break a nail**

crack a nail

develop a split.

break a nail

part of the nail actually breaks off.

Both are possible, but **break a nail** is more common in everyday English.

Important distinction 4: **hit the nail on the head vs be right**

be right

general correctness.

hit the nail on the head

be exactly right about the key point.

> You're right.

你是對的。

> You've hit the nail on the head.

你完全說中了核心。

The idiom is stronger and more vivid.

Important distinction 5: ****hit the nail on the head vs nail it****

These are related but different.

****hit the nail on the head****

correctly identify the key point.

****nail it****

do something extremely well.

> You hit the nail on the head with your diagnosis.

你的分析完全說中。

> You nailed the presentation.

你的簡報做得非常好。

Important distinction 6: ****nail something vs do something well****

****nail something****

informal and emphatic:

= get it exactly right.

****do something well****

neutral.

So:

> She nailed the interview.

has stronger praise than:

> She did well in the interview.

Important distinction 7: ****nail someone vs arrest someone****

****nail someone****

informal, often means catch or obtain enough evidence against them.

****arrest someone****

formal legal action by authorities.

A person may be “nailed” by evidence and then formally arrested.

Important distinction 8: ****nail down vs decide****

****decide****

make a choice.

****nail down****

make uncertain details final and precise.

> decide on a date

選定日期

> nail down the date

把日期正式敲定

****Nail down**** emphasizes removing uncertainty.

Important distinction 9: ****nail down vs pin down****

Very close.

nail down

often finalize/establish precisely.

pin down

often identify precisely or make someone give a definite answer.

> nail down the agreement

敲定協議

> pin down the exact cause

查明確切原因

There is substantial overlap.

Important distinction 10: **a nail in the coffin is figurative**

It comes from the image of sealing a coffin with nails.

Figuratively:

one more event making failure or ending more certain

There is no literal coffin in most uses.

Important distinction 11: **hard as nails does not mean physically metallic**

It describes:

- * toughness,
- * emotional hardness,
- * determination.

Depending on context, it can be positive or negative.

Important distinction 12: **nail-biting literal vs figurative**

Literal

> He was biting his nails.

他正在咬指甲。

Figurative adjective

> a nail-biting match

令人緊張到咬指甲的比賽

Family-extension note

****Nail**** has two major literal noun branches:

1. ****body****

- * fingernail
- * toenail
- * nail polish

2. ****metal fastener****

- * hammer a nail
- * nail something to a wall

From the second branch, English develops powerful figurative meanings:

3. ****exact correctness****

- * hit the nail on the head

4. ****excellent execution****

- * nail it
- * nail the interview

5. ****catch/prove wrongdoing****

- * nail someone

6. ****make definite****

* nail down the details

7. **failure metaphor**

* nail in the coffin

And from the body sense:

8. **nervous suspense**

* nail-biting

* nail-biter

For your passage, the exact expression is:

hit the nail on the head = 正中要害 / 完全做對

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
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nail (body)	指甲；趾甲	hard body part
fingernail	手指甲	finger nail
toenail	腳趾甲	toe nail
bite your nails	咬指甲	nervous habit
nail polish	指甲油	cosmetic
nail file	指甲銼	nail tool
nail (metal)	釘子	fastener
hammer a nail	敲釘子	drive fastener
nail X to Y	把 X 釘在 Y	fasten
hit the nail on the head	正中要害；一語中的	exact correctness
nail it	完美做到；搞定	excellent performance
nail an interview	面試發揮極佳	perform successfully
nail the timing	時機掌握準確	get exactly right
nail someone	抓到 / 逮住某人	catch/prove
nail someone for X	因 X 抓到某人	catch wrongdoing
nail down X	敲定 / 確定 X	make definite
nail down the cause	查明確切原因	identify precisely
nail in the coffin	令失敗更近的一擊	contributes to ending
final nail in the coffin	最後致命一擊	seals failure
fight tooth and nail	拼盡全力	struggle fiercely
as hard as nails	非常強硬 / 堅韌	tough
nail-biting	扣人心弦的	suspenseful

| **nail-biter** | 緊張刺激的事情 | uncertain outcome |

For your original sentence

> That reaction told me I had **hit the nail on the head**.

Here:

hit the nail on the head = 完全選對了；準確抓到媽媽真正會珍惜的東西

The literal image is:

> hitting a nail **exactly on its head** with a hammer

and the figurative idea is:

> getting something **exactly right**

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering in this gift context is:

> 她的反應讓我知道，這份禮物真的**送對了**。

If preserving the idiomatic force more strongly:

> 她的反應讓我知道，我這次真的**正中她心意 / 完全抓對了重點**。